Framing in an Official History: The Collocates of Wei Zhongxian in the Mingshi

Question and Source

The Mingshi (明史) is the official history that the Qing court compiled for the previous dynasty, completed in 1739. While it writes the history of the Ming, it also contains an explanation for the fall of the Ming, so it is not a neutral record. So I want to ask: how does the Mingshi "frame" Wei Zhongxian (魏忠贤)? "Framing" here means how a history builds a fixed image for a person by selecting and combining words. An official history has a clear political position, and the wording itself is a narrative device. if some words repeatedly appear around Wei Zhongxian, they form a semantic field kept on purpose. So my main argument is that the Mingshi writes Wei Zhongxian as an extreme example of eunuch misrule: he uses forging edicts(矫旨) and transmitting edicts(传旨) to exercise a borrowed imperial power, relies on his faction(其党) and living shrines (生祠) to build a network, uses dismissal (削籍) and removal from office(落职) to remove his opponents, and is finally condemned by the the treason case(逆案). This set of words agrees with the Qing explanation that the fall of the Ming was due to 婦寺竊柄, which means women and eunuchs seizing power.

The source is the full text of mingshi, taken from the course repository; the content is the Wikisource transcription of the Mingshi, and it belongs to public domain. The whole book is about 3.28 million characters, in 332 juan. I use it because, as an official history for the previous dynasty, it has to explain the fall of the Ming, which exactly the point I want to examine.

Processing and Method

For processing, I first delete the content that is not the main text, then use opencc to convert to simplified, split the sentences by the end punctuation, segment with jieba, remove the punctuation, drop classical stop words use zh_cl_sim plus a few particles, and keep only the sentences of 5 words or more. I also make another control set of three words or more. The segmenter does not know many personal names, so I use a user dictionary to fix the key names and terms, check about 25 sentences by eye like a few errors remained, mostly jieba merging two common characters, for example, 群击. And also run once with the abbreviated name Zhongxian (忠贤) merged into the target word. To judge whether two words are really related, I count four cases for each pair: both words appear in the window (a), only the collocate appears near the target (b), only the target appears (c), and neither appears (d). These four numbers form a 2×2 table, which find_collocates from qhchina tests with Fisher's exact test. The p-value is the chance of getting a table this strong if the two words were actually unrelated, so a small p means the

pairing is probably not coincidence. A p-value, however, only shows how sure we are, not how tight the tie is, so beside the significance measure log-likelihood I report a strength measure logDice, and compare the two rankings. Because several thousand words are tested at once, I correct with Benjamini Hochberg and keep only adjusted $p<0.05$. I limit the word length to at least two characters and the co-occurrence to at least three. Because classical Chinese sentences are short, I compare three definitions of "near" window 5+5, window 10+10, and same sentence and add a merged abbreviation run and a three-word control, so my interpretation comes from comparing runs, not just from one.

Results and Interpretation

The window 5+5 list has mainly two kinds of words. One kind is relations and names, such as Yang Lian (杨涟), Ke Shi (客氏), and Donglin (东林); the other is narrative verbs, such as forging edicts, transmitting edicts, and dismissal, building shrines (建祠), and the treason case. Words describing character and appearance are almost absent. When the window is enlarged to 10, dismissal and removal from office rise in position, which shows these associations often appear across sentences. The rankings of the two measures also start to separate: after merging the abbreviation, Tianqi (天启) enters only the strength list, and great anger (大怒) enters only the significance list. The most obvious change is forging edicts, which rises from 15th to 2nd after the abbreviation is merged, and transmitting edicts rises to 6th, which shows the abbreviation sentences are mostly about actions like falsely passing imperial orders. The result of the three-word control is basically the same as the main set.

The results suggest that the Mingshi defines Wei Zhongxian along two lines, relations and actions.

The first line is "relations": the one on top of the list, Yang Lian, is exactly the person who impeached him, not his follower. The book repeatedly writes that Yang Lian impeached Wei Zhongxian for twenty-four great crimes (二十四大罪) (juan 22), and elsewhere ties his power to the emperor's voice, as in "魏忠贤矫旨取进，盗窃一空" (juan 79), where jiao marks the forged order. So the narration is built from the impeachment and the purge, using the angle of the victim. By the way, passages are taken from the KWIC concordance, output/kwic.html. The other names also belong to this conflict: Donglin and Zhao Nanxing (赵南星) on the impeachment side, Cui Chengxiu (崔呈秀) and Shi Sanwei (石三畏) attached to him. So Wei Zhongxian in the Mingshi is not an independent person with character, but a center of conflict.

The second line is actions. These actions share one common precondition: they cannot be done without the name of the emperor. The most common are forging edicts and transmitting edicts; the action seems to come from him, but the authority comes from the emperor. Meng Sen (孟森) notes that Wei was illiterate and let Wang Tiqian (王体乾) and others read the memorials and

pass the edicts for him, while the emperor often pushed such matters to them; power slid to him through this handing-over. Besides, words like dismissal and removal from office also cluster around him, showing that he borrowed the imperial order and cleared out his opponents.

His overstepping shows most clearly in living shrines: temples and offerings set up for him while still alive, almost raising him to Confucius's level, with officials calling him Nine Thousand Years (九千岁). These were all settled together after his death, written as the treason case. So the groups 党、祠、旨、刑、案 are more like several links of the same matter, not several independent kinds.

This framing can be compared with the judgment in the section "the Eunuch Calamity of the Tianqi Reign" (天启朝之阉祸) of Meng Sen's Mingshi jiangyi (明史讲义). Meng Sen thinks the eunuch disaster was not only the personal evil of Wei Zhongxian, but also the result of the decline of the dynasty's fortune and a foolish ruler; he points out that Wei's power ran through the emperor's mouth Wang Tiqian read Yang Lian's memorial but skipped the key words; memorials called Wei "the Palace Servant" (厂臣) without his name; the eunuch party was split; and the living shrines and the plan to let Wei share Confucius's sacrifice were the extreme of flattery.My collocations partly match him: Yang Lian on top, and forging edicts, transmitting edicts, his faction, echo his "borrowing the emperor's mouth" and the faction network. The difference is that Meng Sen spreads responsibility to fortune and the emperor, while the Mingshi concentrates it on Wei alone. This shows that an official history easily puts a systemic problem onto one person, and the Qing court wanted to say the fall of the Ming was women and eunuchs seizing power, so it needed such a concrete person. So the collocations show how the official history frames him, while Meng Sen gives the historian's later, more neutral re-reading.

Limitations

The conclusion is affected by several choices. Windows 5 and 10 give two definitions of "how near is near"; the direction of the results is the same, but changing the window still matters. I keep only sentences of five words or more, which loses some short sentences and may lean the result to the longer biographies; the three-word control does not fully remove this bias. Also, the way of handling the full name and the abbreviation changes the ranking, and the influence on forging edicts and transmitting edicts is especially clear. Deleting the name list at the beginning of each juan is reasonable, but after all it is also a deletion, andit will affect the result to some degree. The two character minimum also drops some real one character words. A different source would show whether this framing belongs to the Mingshi alone. The most important point is that collocations alone cannot showwhat Wei Zhongxian actually did; they only reflect how the official text describes him, that is, the voice of the historians and the Qing court, and cannot hear the

voices of those who were suppressed. So this study gives only the official history's perspective, not history itself.

References

Meng Sen. *Mingshi jiangyi*. Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1981, chapter 6, section 2.

Zhang Tingyu (张廷玉) et al. *Mingshi*. Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1974.